explained, was to show the flag to the Chinese, across as wide an area as possible. The Middle Sector was not only geographically massive but also perhaps the most inhospitable region in the world. The Chinese, who were on flat ground, had relatively fewer logistical problems especially since their road network had already come up.

Alpha Company, commanded by Major H. S. Hasabnis, took another week to get to Chushul on foot, where they joined the rear elements of 1/8 GR in building barracks from sun-dried mud bricks. Battalion HQ reached Chushul a few days later, at which stage Alpha Company proceeded to Phobrang in 3-ton vehicles that had driven up via the Indus Valley axis via Nyoma and Dungti. From Phobrang the Jats had to cross the Marsmik-la and establish a base at Hot Springs. There they waited for Bravo Company to show up and proceed into the Galwan River Valley to relieve 1/8 GR who had been there for over a year. Delta Company was also pushed up to Phobrang from where one of its platoons relieved the Gorkhas from the Kongma picket.

It was mid-September by the time the Jats began to replace 1/8 GR troops in the Galwan Sector. Small groups of Gorkhas, concentrated at Hot Springs and hampered by the lack of animal transport, could only start their move towards Chushul by 16 October. Hence, by mid-October 1962, only two battalions (less one company of the Jats which was in the DBO Sector) manned the forward pickets of the Middle Sector including the Galwan Valley. Quite a few of 1/8 GR platoons were in the process of falling back on Chushul.

There was nothing ambiguous in the assessment of HQ Western Command of 114 Brigade’s fighting capability. There were very few troops on the ground, and these too had been dispersed over a massive area. Daulet Singh remained apprehensive about the penny packet deployments in the name of the Forward Policy. In a letter dated 17 August 1962, the general expressed his reservations in writing. ‘Our forward posts in Ladakh are nowhere tactically sited, whereas the Chinese everywhere are’. He went on to state categorically that our deployment was dictated by political considerations, and that he would be failing in his duty if he did not draw attention to the size and shape of the potential threat.

Despite being repeatedly told what the situation was and what the shortcomings were, the operational arm of Army HQ under Kaul refused to